

The 6 Phases at a Glance

What your body is doing from your last meal to your first bite back.

1

Fed State

0–3 HOURS

Your body digests, absorbs and stores your last meal. Insulin rises as glucose is tucked away as glycogen.

TIP Make the last meal count: fiber, protein and slow carbs. Dondre's go-to is a kale stir-fry with sweet potatoes and roasted chickpeas.

2

Post-Absorptive

3–12 HOURS

Digestion wraps up. Your liver releases stored glycogen to keep blood sugar steady, and insulin starts to fall.

TIP Mild hunger comes in waves and passes. Water and plain herbal tea help.

3

Early Fasting

12–24 HOURS

Glycogen runs low and your body leans into fat for fuel. Your liver starts making ketones. Hunger often peaks here.

TIP Stay hydrated, add a pinch of sea salt to water for electrolytes, and try slow breathwork when hunger hits.

4

Ketosis

ABOUT 18–48 HOURS

Your liver turns fat into ketones and your brain adapts to use them. Many people describe steadier energy and a quieter appetite.

TIP Some people hit a rough patch first ("keto flu"). Rest, keep electrolytes up and keep activity light.

5

Autophagy

48–72+ HOURS

Your cells break down and recycle worn-out parts, a deep "housekeeping" process whose discovery won the 2016 Nobel Prize.

TIP Fasts this long need a doctor's OK first. Stop and eat if you feel faint, confused or unwell.

6

Refeeding

OVER 4–24 HOURS

Digestion restarts gradually. How you break the fast decides how good you feel after it.

TIP Hours 0–1: bone broth with a pinch of sea salt. Hours 1–4: clear and light. Hours 4–8: soft foods. Day 2: normal, clean eating.